

Scope Document — Funder Reporting Workflow

Elevate 215 · Nasir Muhammad ·

1. The problem, in their words

Elevate 215 is a Philadelphia nonprofit that funds schools. Every time a funder emails Stacy Holland, Elevate's Executive Director, asking what their money did at a school — eight to ten times a year, worse in the fall — she has to pull together three things that don't talk to each other: notes from Renée Okonkwo (Director of School Investments) on how the school is actually doing, the original grant agreement stating what was promised, and payment records from Priya Raghunathan (Finance and Operations Manager). Stacy goes to Renée first, then tracks down the agreement, then gets payment numbers from Priya — and most of that week is spent waiting on people, not doing the actual work. Once she's stitched it together into whatever format the funder wants, it goes out with nobody else reviewing it — *"nobody's checking it before it goes to the funder. It's just me."* When a funder asks for more than the routine version — quarterly detail, a narrative on what changed mid-year — the same three-source assembly happens under a compressed deadline, with a real chance she has to pull Renée or Priya off their own work to hit it.

2. What we are proposing, and what it gives back

Make Renée's visit notes queryable, not just readable. Right now, finding a pattern across schools means reading every note by hand. This gives back **visibility** — an answer in minutes instead of a week of reading.

Add a second-look check before a report goes to a funder. Right now, nothing catches a mistake before a funder sees it. This gives back **accuracy** — an error surfaces internally, not in a funder's inbox.

Cut the manual reconstruction work specifically on Renée's side. Right now, building a timeline of what happened at a school means reading through her prose notes one visit at a time. With her notes structured, that step shrinks from hours to minutes. This gives back **duration** — a shorter turnaround, especially when a funder asks for more than the routine version.

3. Not in this engagement

The monthly board deck. This carries real financial risk — it caused an actual overspend incident — and Stacy treated it as no less serious than the funder-reporting problem: *"three different problems, three different kinds of risk."* We chose funder reporting first because it's the most tractable of the three — fully internal, with no outside accounting firm's process to work around — not because Stacy ranked it lower.

The Beat the Odds index and richer school data. Stacy called this mission-critical, but was explicit that nobody's assessed what data actually exists or what it would take to add it — *"don't come back and tell me something's feasible if you haven't actually looked."* There's nothing to weigh yet.

4. What is still open

Where does Renée's tag actually live, and who reads it? (*Renée*) Stacy was clear this isn't her call to make — *"that's your job to figure out."*

Would the tagging trade actually work for Renée — not in theory, but when she's behind on notes or running three visits in a week? (*Renée*)

Does Priya have time to review a report, and is she the right person for it? (*Priya*)

Has a grants management system ever actually been scoped with real numbers, or is it still just talk? (*Dev*)

Is richer public education data actually accessible, and what would it take to pull in? (*Marcus*)

What I need from them:

What	Who	By when
Whether the tagging trade works under real conditions	Renée	[real date]
Time and role confirmation for the review step	Priya	[real date]
Whether a grants system has real numbers behind it	Dev	[real date]
Whether richer data is accessible and worth pulling in	Marcus	[real date]

Research Memo — Elevate 215

Nasir Muhammad · September 2026

What the organization does

Elevate 215 is a Philadelphia nonprofit that funds schools — public district, public charter, and private — to increase the number of quality schools in the city, serving 16,600+ students across its current portfolio (elevate215.org/about). Its core program, Beat the Odds, funds schools that significantly outperform what their demographics predict. Revenue comes almost entirely from contributions and grants (93.1% of FY2025 revenue), with named funders including the William Penn Foundation and the Lenfest Institute (ProPublica; elevate215.org/news).

Role of the person interviewed

Dr. Stacy Holland is Executive Director, accountable for final sign-off on every funding decision. Her Investment Team — Renée Okonkwo (Director of School Investments) and Marcus Feld (Program Officer) — scouts schools, runs site visits, and brings her a recommendation; she approves, adjusts, or declines it. Board approval follows, described as light-touch but not automatic. Renée and Marcus operate as a tightly coordinated team during spring/summer application season and independently the rest of the year (confirmed by Stacy directly, transcript one — *needs its own E-number; not E01/E09–E12, which belong to the funder-reporting workflow instead*).

What was known before the first conversation, and where it came from

Prior to the interview, public research established Elevate's programs, leadership, board, and FY2025 financials (elevate215.org; ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer), along with a real gap: no public source stated how Elevate's data or finance systems actually work day to day, or what tools staff use. That gap became the opening question of the first interview.

Sourcing note

Every claim above is either sourced publicly (cited by URL) or drawn from a numbered interview quote (E-number). No claim in this memo is presented without one of those two sources.

Interview Summary — Elevate 215

Nasir Muhammad · September 2026 · synthesized across three conversations with Stacy Holland

“All of our data sits in different places, and we’re unable to actually analyze anything, so we’re doing everything by hand. And I’m the one doing it.”

That’s the shape of all three problems I raised: the data itself is fine — clean, complete, kept by people who know what they’re doing — but nothing lives in one place, and nobody but me is trying to look across it at once. I’m the single-person bottleneck for anything that needs more than one system.

Problem one — funder reports (a time problem)

A funder asks what their money did at a school, and I cannot answer it without three people and a week — Renée’s notes, the grant agreement, and Priya’s payment records don’t talk to each other. That happens eight to ten times a year, worse in the fall. Nobody checks my work before it goes out — it’s just me. And it’s worse than it looks: fall and winter, when funders are asking, Renée and Marcus aren’t already talking daily the way they are during spring application season, so I’m not just gathering information, I’m reconstructing context that used to be fresh.

Problem two — the monthly close (a financial-risk problem)

The firm rebuilds the forecast after close, and if something changes in QuickBooks after that, my deck doesn’t know. I’ve got a QuickBooks login I’ve never used. We had a restricted grant where the spend looked fine in my deck, and it turned out we’d overspent — a finance committee member caught it, and I had to follow up with a correction. That was embarrassing. I’m presenting off a snapshot that’s already stale by the time I use it.

Problem three — the Beat the Odds data question (a mission problem)

The index runs on one year of test scores. Our whole thesis is funding schools that outperform what you’d predict, and I’m running that off one slice of data. The state changed how it reported a demographic field a couple years back, and Marcus caught it only because he was spot-checking — if he hadn’t, we’d have made funding decisions off wrong data. We’re only as good as his ability to catch that, and he’s one person.

What I want

I want to ask a plain question and get an answer, without waiting on Renée or an analyst every time. I don’t want to learn a new system or figure out field names. What would tell me it worked: the week becomes two days and the rework disappears; the number in my deck matches QuickBooks every time I present; I know I’m funding the right schools off more than one year of data.

Don’t come back with a third of the picture. Come back with all three, or tell me why you’re setting one aside.

Before-Map, Final — Funder Reporting Workflow

Nasir Muhammad · September 2026 · Elevate 215

■ Black — confirmed/traced ■ Blue — open question ■ Red — friction / rework □ Grey dashed — named, not drawn

E01 · E08 · E02

Funder emails asking what their money did at a school. ~8x/yr, more in fall.

2193

E03 · E06 · E26 · E27

Ren's 2014 grant metrics from fall/spring visits + October reports. Kept in her own prose notes, one per school per visit.

E05

Grant agreement 2014 what was promised to fund & measure.

E04

Priya / QuickBooks 2014 payment records. Clean.

E09 2192 E10 2192 E11 · E12

Step 1: pull Ren's notes. Step 2: track down the agreement. Step 3: get payment records from Priya. Most of the week is waiting.

E15

Output: Word doc, email, or spreadsheet 2014 depends on the funder

E21 · E22

Custom build every time 2014 no way to just pull it

E18 00b7 E19 00b7 E20

Under deadline (10x14 days): same mechanism, quarterly detail required

E23 2014 confirmed

No review step exists. Straight from Stacy to the funder.

Friction

E07 2014 Can't pull trends or off-track counts without asking Ren or reading every note

E13 · E14 2014 Grant agreement storage inconsistent; sometimes dig through email to find it

E16 · E17 2014 Fall/winter: Ren & Marcus desynced 2192 bottleneck worse, most of the year

E24

Monthly close 2014 not drawn here

E25

Index refresh 2014 not drawn here

